FT FollowThrough

The Painting Playbook

What to say from the first call to the five-star review. Copy the lines, put them in your own words, and keep this on your phone.

1. The first call or message

Sound calm, understand the job, and book a next step. Ask:

- Inside or outside, and which rooms or sides of the house?
- Same colors, or a change? Dark to light usually means an extra coat.
- Is there peeling, cracking or bare wood? When was the house built? (Before 1978 means lead-safe rules.)
- When do you need it done, and is there a date like a party or a sale?

> “Thanks for calling [Business], this is [Name]. Tell me about the project and I’ll see how we can help.”

> “Can you send a few photos? I can come by to measure Tuesday at 10 or Wednesday at 4. Which works better?”

2. Presenting the quote

- List every wall, ceiling, trim piece and door, the number of coats, the paint line and the sheen.
- Put prep on its own line: scraping, patching, caulking, priming. It’s what makes the job last.
- Offer good, better, best paint lines when it fits, and say who moves the furniture.
- Give a written schedule and say how long the quote holds.

> “Here’s what’s included, here’s how we’ll prep it, and here’s the price. I can start on [day]. What questions do you have?”

3. The 7 objections painters hear and what to say

Acknowledge it, ask a question, answer honestly, suggest a next step.

1. “Another painter quoted a lot less.”
“That’s fair, I’d compare too. How many coats, what paint and how much prep is in their quote? That’s where painting prices differ. I’ll send you photos of a two-year-old job of mine so you can see how the prep holds up.”

2. “I’m getting a few more quotes.”
“Good idea. What matters most to you, the finish or the timeline? Ask each painter the same things: paint brand and line, number of coats, what prep they do, and whether they’re lead-safe certified if your home is from before 1978. I’ll check in Tuesday.”

3. “Can you knock something off?”
“I can trim the scope to fit a budget, like one coat on walls staying the same color, or ceilings later. What number did you have in mind? I won’t skip prep, because that’s what keeps paint from peeling.”

4. “We’ll just paint it ourselves.”
“Plenty of people do. Which part are you dreading most? Many customers paint the easy walls and hire out ceilings, stairwells and trim. I can quote just those parts.”

5. “Let’s wait until next spring.”
“That can work. Have you noticed peeling or bare wood yet? Once wood is exposed, water gets in, and next year’s job can include rot repair. I can spot-prime the worst areas now and book you early for spring.”

6. “Will you finish on time, and will my house be a mess?”
“Fair question, painters get that a lot. What’s your deadline? I’ll give you a written schedule, cover floors and furniture, and clean up every day. Here are three recent customers you can call.”

7. “Why do you want a deposit?”
“It pays for your paint and supplies, which I order in your colors. How would you like to pay? It’s in the contract, and the balance is due after we walk through the job together and you’re happy.”

4. Follow up: day 2, day 5, day 12

Most quotes go quiet, not “no”. Keep each message short and useful.

> **Day 2:** “Hi [Name], it’s [Your name] from [Business]. Did the painting quote come through okay? Happy to answer any questions about colors or prep.”

> **Day 5:** “Hi [Name], here are a few photos of a similar job we finished last month. I have an opening on [day] and can hold it for you until Friday.”

> **Day 12:** “Hi [Name], I’ll close out your quote on Friday so I can plan the schedule. If you’d still like to go ahead, reply and I’ll hold a spot.”

People compare painters for weeks. Photos of a finished room like theirs do more than any reminder.

5. Ask for the review and the referral

Ask at the final walk-through, when they’re happiest, and text a direct link to your Google review page.

> “Thanks again, [Name]. If you’re happy with how it looks, would you leave a quick Google review with a photo? I’ll text you the link. And if a friend is thinking about painting, I’d be glad to help.”

Leave a labeled can of each color for touch-ups, with your number on the lid.

Three rules that keep you out of trouble

- On homes built before 1978, get EPA lead-safe certified and hand out the Renovate Right pamphlet before you sand or scrape.
- Carry cover for property damage and overspray. One spilled gallon can cost more than the job paid.
- Put the scope in writing, and add a clause for rotten wood found while scraping, priced per linear foot.

General education, not legal, tax or insurance advice. Rules and prices vary by state, so check yours.
The full start-up guide for painters: followthroughguides.com/painting · Questions: info@followthroughguides.com